Rightsizing or Downsizing

Whenever we think of rightsizing, we always think in terms of some drastic reduction from somewhere. However, there is no such magic wand, where suddenly 50,000 troops are reduced in one fell swoop. There are, however, many areas that simple housekeeping can address, resulting in small savings that, when applied across the Army, still result in savings in manpower, without in any way compromising operational effectiveness. Many of the structures and organizations that were born out of necessity at a certain point in time were now redundant. Take the Military Farms, for example, which supplied fresh milk to Army garrisons. At some point in time, it was a necessity in the absence of adequate storage and refrigeration facilities. But times had changed, milk was available in every corner kirana shop or supplied in Tetra Packs. Quite rightly, the Shekatkar Committee, which was constituted to examine reforms in the MoD, recommended its closure and this has been implemented.

One aspect that had caught my attention from my Phulbari (Brigade) days, ever since Isha had looked at me incredulously was the continued necessity of having mules. Times had changed, even in the forty years that I had been in service. Almost all the posts, where we had to walk up earlier, were now connected by road. Whenever I used to visit units, I would always ask them how they had been utilizing the mules allotted to them. In most cases, the answer was that the mules were there but used only in emergencies. Whether used or not, the mules had to be watered and fed, and proper stables catered for, with their dedicated handlers. This was quite the underutilization of resources and wasteful expenditure. Moreover, with the advent of drones, even called 'mule-drones', which could carry loads of 20 to 30 kg, clearly the days of Animal Transport were over.

Copyright © Penguin Random House India
Not for circulation